

MBAI 5410: Digital Transformation

Business Model & Transformation Opportunities

Sorbara

A Gafoor, K Snow, A Balkarran, M Kayode
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Transformation Focus Area: Organizational Coordination, information flow and decision structure

Sorbara currently has several operational bottlenecks, which are symptoms of deeper structural issues within its organizational systems. This can happen as a small company grows quickly, but past practices and system infrastructure are not updated to keep pace with that growth, leaving inefficiencies behind. Creating an overall structure/design of how information and decisions are moved through different levels of the organization, as well as different functional areas, can help improve overall operations and ensure they can operate at a competitive level with other companies who used early digitization to improve operational efficiencies (Coster et al., 2023).

There are current limitations to improving overall organizational coordination and information flow that Sorbara clearly identified. The first group of limitations is process-related, including manual workflows, paper-based systems, informal approvals, decentralized processes, and outsourced processes. The second group of limitations Sorbara faces is system and infrastructure issues, including system limitations, patchwork systems that do not integrate with legacy systems, technical skills gaps, and a lack of real-time data access and efficient reporting methods. The third group of limitations revolves around knowledge dependency, with a lot of processes that are a mystery to all except those that do them and no central knowledge base, making Sorbara dependent on individuals and creating high risk if those individuals leave the company. Finally, the last group of limitations revolves around employees and overall culture, with change resistance, employees at capacity and unable to put work in to make change and leadership being largely conservative around technological improvements. Many of these limitations stem from siloed teams and the large number of differentiated growth business units, which create friction and highlight process breakdowns. These limitations of the current system cause slow decision cycles, duplication of work, information distortion, high risk due to knowledge concentrations, and the inability to scale operations effectively.

Updating the organizational system not only will improve internal operations but is also essential due to the external and environmental pressures Sorbara faces. These pressures include the overall competitiveness of the market, with expectations of operational maturity and a required level of speed in responses. In addition, technology is rapidly evolving with the introduction of AI, giving competitors a competitive advantage. We must also consider regulatory and government expectations to ensure compliance and accountability across all levels of the business. Finally, client, partner, and government expectations should all be considered, as they will want reliability, stability, and ease of coordination.

Strategic Justification

These limitations of the current system cause slow decision cycles, duplication of work, information distortion, high risk due to knowledge concentrations, and the inability to scale operations effectively. Highlighting that these bottlenecks are not just creating inefficiencies, but overall strategic fragility. Eliminating this fragility is essential to achieving overall organizational resiliency and efficiency, ensuring long-term competitive advantage. In addition, it helps eliminate current risks associated with knowledge silos, data integrity and fraud. Overall, improving

organizational coordination, information flow and decision structure will increase productivity and free up employees for more high-value work by eliminating administrative burdens.

Transformation Opportunity Options

The transformation opportunity options proposed for Sorbara Group's digital transformation focus on improving organizational coordination, information flow and decision structure, and are detailed below:

Land Acquisition

This transformational opportunity seeks to leverage Sorbara's past development experience and market data patterns to identify profitable land acquisition opportunities. Here, the company will no longer rely solely on staff's personal networks and land-acquisition sourcing skills and expertise to source land for profitable redevelopment. Instead of manual searches and contacts, automated triggers can be set up to alert the company to potential profitable acquisition opportunities.

The knowledge and expertise of Sorbara's staff will be converted into company knowledge, which will prevent important information from being lost and keep the company operating smoothly in the event of staff leaving. The evaluation criteria used for land acquisition decisions will equally be formalized and standardized.

These measures will ensure that Sorbara transforms its land acquisition process, moving from reactive to proactive. This will also signify a shift from relying solely on individual expertise to building company-owned predictive capabilities.

Timesheet Enhancement

The enhancement of the timesheet process will involve a shift from a system with frequent errors and rework to one that is more accurate and timely. This will reduce the frustration experienced by staff and save time that is currently being spent on corrections.

The time and effort saved by the enhancements will, in turn, increase staff efficiency. Manual processing will be replaced by automation, allowing staff to spend more time on their actual work rather than fixing errors and doing rework.

Delays or errors in the payment of staff salaries will equally be avoided. Management and Staff alike will also have access to accurate data, which will help provide clarity, transparency, and input for planning and budgeting purposes.

Streamlined Reporting

Currently, Sorbara's Property Management and accounting groups lack important and substantial reporting insights from their ERP system. Streamlined reporting as a transformation option will enable faster access to and greater visibility into insights derived from their data.

Key and relevant information will be extracted from the company's data and presented in clear, easy-to-read formats. The staff are therefore able to make sense of the information provided and draw meaningful insights important for strategy, planning, and decision-making.

The same information will also be accessible to the groups in question, preventing any disconnects or discrepancies and facilitating collaboration across the groups.

Hence, Sorbara will be able to move from the absence of meaningful reporting insights to the presence of accessible, relevant and clear reporting insights. This will, in no small measure,

ensure that Sorbara can address issues identified through the insights in a timely manner and implement strategies to remain profitable, competitive, and one step ahead of the market.

Business Model Impact

The shift from manual, decentralized reporting to centralized processes is set to significantly improve both security and efficiency. This transformation is mainly driven by crucial business areas, including Finance, Business Solutions, and Land Development, with a focus on enhancing Time Sheet management, Land Acquisition, and Streamlined Reporting.

Image 1 illustrates the business impact, activities, constraints, and features associated with this change, while Chart 1 outlines the specific responsibilities of each participating business unit.

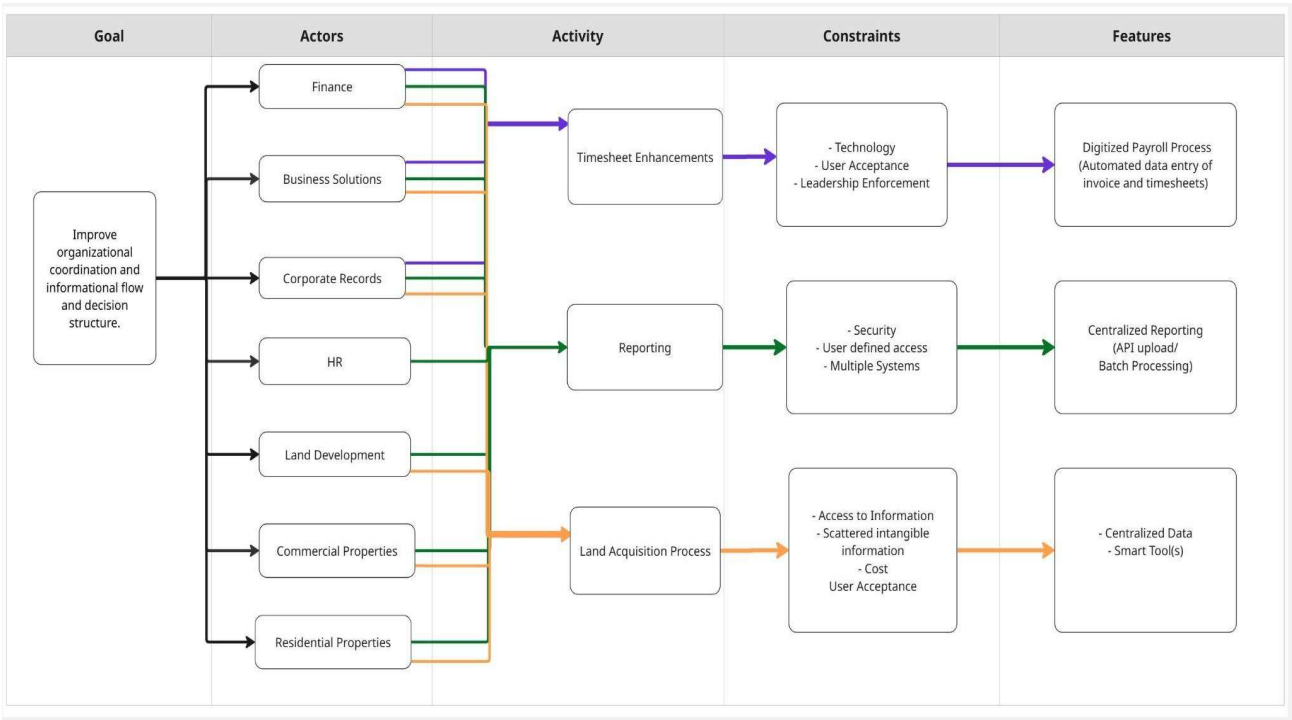


Image 1: Business Flow Chart https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVG9Wsrbo=

Business Unit	Primary Role	Transformation Responsibilities
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Finance	Process Owner	AP, Payroll workflows, and reporting standardization
Business Solutions	Technology Enablers	System integrations, Tools, API strategies
Corporate Records	Compliance and Data Governance	Records digitization, retention rules, and access control
HR	Workforce Transformation	Digital onboarding, timesheet automation, training
Land Development	Process Owner	Land acquisition workflow redesign, Business Investments (REITS)
Commercial Properties	Operational Processes	Lease management, reporting automation
Residential Properties	Operational Processes	Tenant lifecycle digitization

Chart 1. Business Unit Responsibilities

Timesheet Enhancement

Current Process:

The current process for handling timesheet payments relies heavily on manual data entry. This creates inefficiencies and increases the risk of errors, including mistakes and delays. These issues are especially important given the different types of employment, such as unionized, non-unionized, and various contractor roles.

Employees and contractors submit paper timesheets. The Finance team then has to enter this information manually into both the financial reporting system and the payments system. This results in multiple entries that can be prone to mistakes. Resistance to change is evident; for example, in 2022, field staff still used printed timesheets.

To improve this situation, a digital solution called "Jibble Work" was introduced. This tool includes API integrations and helps manage time zone differences for field teams. However, a key leader in the business resisted the change and prefers to stick with paper methods, citing concerns about reducing on-site operations. As a result, the timesheet enhancement needs to improve payroll operations and solve payment processing issues.

Main Impact Areas: Finance, Business Solutions, Corporate Records, Employees/Contractors(payees)

Other Areas of Impact

Payments primarily impact Finance, Business Solutions, and Corporate Records, while also affecting operations units and contractors. Supporting departments, such as Legal, Compliance, Treasury, and Reporting, play a crucial role in reviewing contractual agreements and ensuring adherence to all relevant rules and regulations.

Impact Area	Impact	Benefits
Finance	The aim is to reduce manual processes of reporting and issuing payments.	Additional benefits include improved security and reduced risks of error from manual entries.
Business Solutions	Centralized configuration of user and role permissions	The administrators would have to assign employees a role, with permissions, that allow automatic timesheet continuance
Corporate Records	Audit Trail visibility	Surfacing timesheet audits creates a digital footprint of the timesheet entry
Commercial/ Residential/ Land Development	Immediate sign-in for employees	These are the consumers of the improved timesheet process
Employee/Contractor	Data Capture	Time reduction for timesheet processing. Timely payments

Chart 2. Impact for Timesheet Enhancement

Potential Change

To reduce risks and improve process efficiency during the initiation phases, it is advisable to implement software solutions that allow for direct data capture from timesheets. This approach ensures both accuracy and data integrity. Additionally, utilizing an API to upload this data to the relevant systems for financial reporting and payment processing is recommended. Payments can then be aggregated and processed during a day-end run, facilitating the transfer of funds from the financial reporting system to an automated bank payment system for each payee.

Risk (Current)	Potential Gains (Change)
- Recording Error - Timeless Entries - Multi-touch points with data - Keying Errors	- Reduced hours - Minimize risk of data entry error - Security and Access Controls - Efficient reporting and payments

Chart 3. Risk and Gain for Timesheet Enhancements

Land Acquisition Process

Current Process:

The land acquisition process is managed by the Vice President of Land Development. It begins with assessments and research on cities, municipalities, and zoning regulations. The findings are then presented to an advisory board for funding approval, where the VP of Land Development must demonstrate the project's viability through his experience and supporting evidence.

Currently, the Land acquisition team primarily rely on Excel, with digital systems integrated only during the construction phase. A significant challenge is identifying off-market property opportunities, as critical data is sourced from Altus Group reports that do not provide access to raw data. Budgeting and long-term planning are conducted in isolated Excel spreadsheets, lacking integration with the main ERP system.

The company adopts a long-term perspective on land development, often spanning over a decade and requiring extensive planning, council meetings, legal proceedings, and political engagement.

Impact Areas:

Land Development, Finance, Business Solutions, Corporate Records, Executive Board

Areas of Impact

Impact Area	Impact	Why
Finance	Treasury and reporting are impacted directly by acquisitions and sales.	Reporting and tracking for ongoing developments.
Business Solutions	Centralized configuration of user and role permissions	The administrators would have to assign employees a role, with permissions, that allow automatic timesheet continuance
Corporate Records	Audit Trail visibility	Surfacing timesheet audits creates a digital footprint of the timesheet entry
Commercial/ Residential/ Land Development	Immediate sign-in for employees	These are the consumers of the improved timesheet process
Executive Board	Decision Makers	Information to support Investment decisions

Chart 4: Impacts for Land Acquisition

Potential Change

Potential changes to land acquisition include centralizing information and developing a tool to report on and track leads, identify potential development opportunities, assess property valuations for enhancement, and trigger workflow items.

First, we need to identify the data sources required for this tool, the workflow items, and the predefined procedures. Important data points to consider include maps, zoning information, property lines, property valuations, and details about developed areas for commercial, residential, and environmental purposes. These data points can be obtained from a data provider and uploaded to create a knowledge base for use within the system. The data files can be uploaded manually or through an API to ensure access to up-to-date information. Once uploaded, this data can be displayed on a map using applications such as Esri's ArcGIS or other similar tools, creating a dashboard tailored to development acquisitions. This dashboard would include built-in reporting capabilities and workflows.

In summary, the conceptual flow of data through this system will generate useful, meaningful information that can be used to identify new business opportunities, follow leads and turn potential into actual.

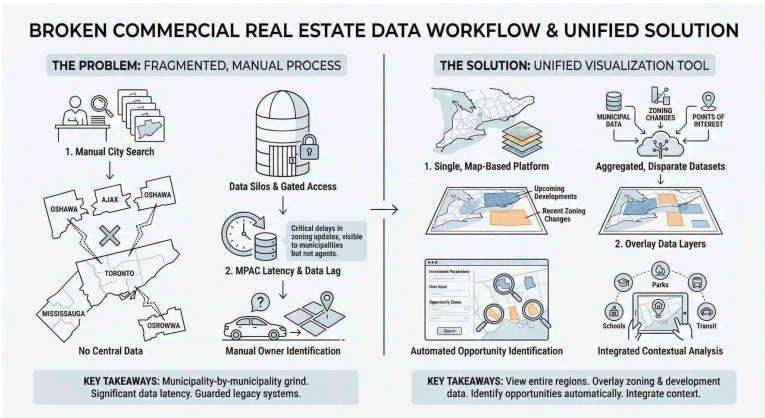


Image 2 Conceptual Flow

Risk (Current)	Potential Gains (Change)
- Limited or lacking succession plan - Limited information - No knowledge sharing - Paper-based and not online - Limited Growth	- Succession Plan - Documented process - Reduced Risk of Loss - Increased Opportunities - Portfolio Growth - Automated Systems - Digital Assets

Chart 5: Land Acquisition Risks and Gains

Reporting

Current Process:

Key departments within Sorbara lack oversight of all the necessary reporting available through the current ERP system. Departments like accounting and finance are maintaining reporting on Excel outside of the system. This process exposes Sorbara to compliance, audit, and financial risks.

Impact Areas:

Finance, Business Solutions, Corporate Records, HR, Commercial, Residential

Areas of Impact

Impact Area	Impact	Why
Finance	Treasury and reporting are impacted directly by acquisitions and sales.	Reporting and tracking for ongoing developments.
Business Solutions	Centralized configuration of user and role permissions	The administrators would have to assign employees a role, with permissions, that allow automatic timesheet continuance
Corporate Records	Audit Trail visibility	Surfacing timesheet audits creates a digital footprint of the timesheet entry
Commercial/ Residential/ Land Development	Immediate sign-in for employees	These are the consumers of the improved timesheet process
Executive Board	Decision Makers	Information to support Investment decisions

Chart 5: Impact for Reporting

Potential Change

The potential enhancement for Sorbara is to first inventory all required reports and identify key stakeholders, the purpose, and the requirements. Information that can be pulled from the available systems includes a queryable dashboard that generates the requested reports. If reports are required at a specific frequency, an API is used to run the report and deliver it to the appropriate stakeholders. Access and limitation can be set for view-only or modifiable options for those who need it. Streamlining the report will limit exposure to errors and misinformation.

Risk (Current)	Potential Gains (Change)
- Limited or lacking succession plan - Limited information - No knowledge sharing - Paper-based and not online - Limited Growth	- Succession Plan - Documented process - Reduced Risk of Loss - Increased Opportunities - Portfolio Growth - Automated Systems - Digital Assets

Chart 7: Land Acquisition Risks and Gains

Initial Decision Framing

There are several opportunities for Sorbara to enhance the overall efficiency of its business. In this section, we examine the transformation options for the Company against “Key Uncertainties”, “Key Trade-Offs” and “deciding what matters the most when deciding between options”.

1. Land Acquisition:

a. Key Uncertainties:

- i.* Can structure/process be added without reducing the flexibility of land acquisitions?
- ii.* Will the expert be willing to share knowledge?
- iii.* Will the expert’s network be willing to share information with other persons?
- iv.* Is the company ready to formalize the evaluation criteria?

b. Key Trade-Offs:

- i.* Standardization vs. flexibility in acquisition decisions
- ii.* Speed of decision-making vs. deep analysis of data
- iii.* Preserving individual expertise vs. company resilience

c. What Matters Most in Choosing Options:

- i.* Options that maintain flexibility while providing structured evaluation
- ii.* Options that build company resilience without over relying on a single person
- iii.* Options that encourage company learning based on past acquisitions

2. Timesheet Enhancement

a. Key Uncertainties:

- i. How willing are off-site employees to adapt to a structured system/process?
- ii. Will leadership enforce process changes?

b. Key Trade-Offs

- i. Short term disruption during implementation vs. long term efficiency
- ii. Purchasing an off-the-shelf solution vs. a customized solution

c. What Matters Most in Choosing Options:

- i. An option that ensures smooth adoption and data accuracy

3. Streamlined Reporting

a. Key Uncertainties:

- i. Will all levels of management use the system?
- ii. How much data access can be granted without a security breach?

b. Key Trade-Offs:

- i. Ease of data access vs. data security
- ii. Transparency vs. control

c. What Matters Most in Choosing Options:

- i. Options that are user-friendly and secure
- ii. Options that integrate past data
- iii. Options that improve transparency and decision quality

Assumptions: Our group assumes that Sorbara values long-term sustainability and that leadership is willing to take the necessary steps to guarantee business resilience in a competitive landscape. Our team may also have a few biases/ blind spots. These may include us:

1. Looking for evidence supporting the company's capabilities to adapt and provide state-of-the-art solutions because it aligns with the "digital transformation" narrative.
2. Assuming stakeholders will readily adapt to new processes while overlooking their resistance to change.

Making assumptions while ignoring our biases (and/or blind spots) may lead us to provide an optimal solution that the company cannot implement, ultimately bringing no value to the company.

References

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